

LEADER SUPREME

The power of the Congress president extends beyond the party

Madam President

Foisted her personal choice of presidential candidate on UPA and the Left. Engineered the selection to make it appear as a consensus. Closely monitored the election campaign. Met Congress MPs in batches coaching them on how to fill the ballot paper.

Legislative Control

Pilots socially-correct policies such as Rural Employment Bill, Right to Information Act, Tribals Bill. Her current obsession is a rehabilitation policy for those affected by the Narmada Dam. Responding to public mood in the Jessica Lal case, told Home Ministry to strengthen witness protection measures.

Economic Rollback

Reaction to economic policies are populist. Got the Government to partially roll back petroleum price hike last June, to reconsider FDI in retail, the SEZ policy and signing FTAs. Also piloted a CWC resolution against rising prices.

Renunciation Drama

Resigned both from NAC and as an MP during the office-of-profit controversy. Got the act amended and re-elected. Even though she is still to take over NAC officially, it continues to influence policies.

Letter and Spirit

Monitors government through weekly core group meets. Has written over 30 letters to sundry ministries such as Commerce (to look after small-scale leather industry), Finance (to waive tax for Kashmiri migrants) and Agriculture (to ensure a pro-farmer Seeds Bill).



IN CONTROL: While dealing with allies (above), Sonia opts for a consensus but for personal political decisions, she consults Rahul and Priyanka (below)



vant. I have not met anyone who is so kindhearted, who remembers a favour, who is so charitable and sacrificial as her," gushes Lalu. Privately some Congressmen feel that Sonia finds it tough to say no to Lalu—whether it is about tainted ministers in the Cabinet or imposing President's Rule in Bihar.

Yet at the end of the day, she gets the best out of her allies and has a pointsman in each party. As she is still to forgive Pawar for making an issue of her foreign origin, she prefers to deal with the more urbane Praful Patel. In the Left, it is the congenial Sitaram Yechury not the stern Prakash Karat, who has replaced H.S. Surjeet as Sonia's favourite communist. Yechury calls her regularly to discuss issues ranging from the Indo-US nuclear deal to changes in the legislation on special economic zones. Sonia has learnt that speaking the language of drawing-room socialism will enhance her appeal even among her regional allies. The Left swears by the UPA chairper-

son's ability to maintain unity within the alliance despite the fact that TRS and MDMK left UPA in 2006 and 2007, respectively. She seldom consults the Left on political matters. Yet its leaders say she "interacts, informs, listens and thanks the allies of the Congress". Her closest allies remain her children. When it comes to governance, she may opt for consensus, but when it comes to taking decisions that affect her directly, she consults only Rahul and Priyanka.

She has been accused of promoting a socialist rather than a pro-reforms agenda in the Government, pushing through politically-correct legislations such as the National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme (NREG), Domestic Violence Bill and the Right to Information Act. To ensure that the Left didn't take credit for NREG, Sonia made a rare speech in Parliament. Union ministers Renuka Chowdhury and Mani Shankar Aiyar are grateful to her lobbying with the finance min-